

BUILT IN Dawid & Annemarie de Greeff · 11 Oct 2026 · 56 min read

Beholding: Becoming What We Gaze Upon

We become what we behold. God calls hard-hearted people to look at Him, and shows Himself to us in Jesus, the perfect image of the Father. As we keep looking, the Holy Spirit changes us into His likeness and builds us together as living stones into one wall that reflects His light.

2 Corinthians 3:18 ↗ John 14:9 ↗ Hebrews 1:3 ↗ Philippians 2:5-8 ↗ Ezekiel 36:26 ↗ 1 Peter 2:4-5 ↗ Revelation 21:23 ↗

Summary

We become what we behold. Every person is always looking at something, and what we look at shapes us. God, in His mercy, calls hard-hearted people to look at Him. He shows Himself to us in His Son: Jesus is the perfect image of the Father. When we turn and keep looking at Jesus as the Scriptures show Him, the Holy Spirit changes us into His likeness, from one degree of glory to the next. And He does not leave us as loose stones. He builds us together on Jesus, the Cornerstone, into one living wall that reflects His glory to the world.

> God takes hearts as hard as stone and softens them by His Spirit, so that they can behold Jesus. Then He turns them into living gemstones. He doesn't leave

> us as loose stones on a pile. He builds us firmly on Jesus, the Cornerstone, so that when the world looks at the Church, it sees the reflected glory of the Father.

Key verses

> *"And we all, with unveiled face, beholding the glory of the Lord, are being transformed into the same image from one degree of glory to another. For this comes from the Lord who is the Spirit."* (2 Corinthians 3:18)

> *"Whoever has seen me has seen the Father."* (John 14:9)

> *"As you come to him, a living stone rejected by men but in the sight of God chosen and precious, you yourselves like living stones are being built up as a spiritual house."* (1 Peter 2:4–5)

How this article is built

- **Part A: What God shows us** (sections 1–4): God's call, what beholding means, Jesus as the image of the Father, and what that image looks like.
- **Part B: What happens to those who look** (sections 5–10): new hearts, the three directions we can look, wrong ways of looking, how we behold today, being built in together, and the wall of precious stones.
- Each section ends with a short **conclusion** and **supporting verses**.
- **Annemarie's** experiences are marked as hers.
- Scripture is quoted from the ESV unless noted. Where something is interpretation rather than plain text, it says so.

Part A — What God shows us

Before we can talk about how we change, we need to see what God has shown us. Beholding does not start with us. It starts with God calling, God showing, and God giving us eyes to see.

1 God calls: "Behold!"

God speaks first. In the garden, after Adam and Eve had sinned and hidden themselves, it was God who came looking: *"Where are you?"* (Genesis 3:9). That pattern runs through the whole Bible. We do not find our way to God. God comes to us and calls.



“Behold, the Lamb of God!” (John 1:29)

"Behold!" is God pointing. The Bible often uses a small word that we easily skip over: *behold*. In Hebrew it is *hinneh*; in Greek, *idou* or *ide*. It means: "Look! Pay attention! See this!" It is the voice of someone pointing at something we must not miss. When John the Baptist sees Jesus coming, he does exactly this: *"Behold, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!"* (John 1:29). Beholding is first of all a response to someone else's call.

God calls people who need mercy. The people God calls are not the strong and the deserving. They are people with hard hearts, hiding from Him, unable to save themselves. The world we live in is hard and often merciless. It measures us by how we perform, compares us to others, and steps on those who fail. Into that world God speaks with mercy: *"But God, being rich in mercy, because of the great love with which he loved us, even when we were dead in our trespasses, made us alive together with Christ"* (Ephesians 2:4–5). Judgement and the law can make a heart harder. Only mercy can soften it.



The cure was not a task. It was a look.

Look and live. When Israel was dying from snakebites in the wilderness, God told Moses to make a bronze serpent and put it on a pole. Anyone who was bitten and *looked* at it lived (Numbers 21:8–9). Jesus applied this picture to Himself: *"As Moses lifted up the serpent in the wilderness, so must the Son of Man be lifted up, that whoever believes in him may have eternal life"* (John 3:14–15). The cure was not a task to perform. It was a look. Isaiah carries the same call to the whole world: *"Turn to me and be saved, all the ends of the earth! For I am God, and there is no other"* (Isaiah 45:22; the KJV reads "Look unto me"). In 1850 a teenager named Charles Spurgeon heard a lay preacher press this verse on a small congregation in a snowstorm: "Look! Look!" He looked, and became one of the greatest preachers of his century.



A snowy Sunday in 1850: “Look unto me, and be ye saved.”

He looks at us first. Before we ever look at Jesus, He has already looked at us. *"And Jesus, looking at him, loved him"* (Mark 10:21). He looked up into the tree at Zacchaeus and called him by name (Luke 19:5). On the night Peter denied Him

three times, *"the Lord turned and looked at Peter"* (Luke 22:61), and that look broke Peter's heart and later restored him. *"We love because he first loved us"* (1 John 4:19). In the same way, we behold because He first beheld us.

We behold because He first beheld us.

Creation calls too. *"The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork"* (Psalm 19:1). Every sunrise is a small "Behold!" pointing past itself to its Maker. As Paul Washer said of a sunrise he loved: *"That's nothing but a drop of paint off the brush of my Lord."*

In short. Beholding begins with God, not with us. He speaks first, He calls hard-hearted people in mercy, and He looks at us before we look at Him. Our part begins as a response: we turn and look.

Supporting verses: Genesis 3:9 · John 1:29 · Ephesians 2:4–5 · Numbers 21:8–9 · John 3:14–15 · Isaiah 45:22 · Mark 10:21 · Luke 19:5 · Luke 22:61 · 1 John 4:19 · Psalm 19:1 · Hebrews 1:1–2

2 What it means to behold

Three ways of looking. The Bible uses more than one word for seeing. In Hebrew the plain word is *ra'ah*: to see, to glance. A deeper word is *chazah*: to gaze, to fix your eyes on something and drink it in until it changes you. It is the word used for a prophet's vision, and the word David uses in Psalm 27:4.

	WHAT HAPPENS	EXAMPLE
Glance (*ra'ah*)	The eyes pass over something	Scrolling past a photo
Gaze (*chazah*)	The eyes stay, steady and long	Watching a sunset until it's gone
Behold	The eyes *and the heart* arrive, and we truly see	One line in the Bible stops you, because suddenly you see Jesus in it

Annemarie's experience. *"When my dad was ill in hospital in Bloem, I drove between Kimberley and Bloem every day, and I saw the most spectacular sunsets I've ever seen. All I wanted to do was stare at the colours in the sky. Or at the beach, in the late afternoons, I just want to sit and watch how the waves keep rolling in, time after time, how the water builds up and crashes down. When we went to the Vanderkloof Dam and that water was rushing down, I just wanted to stand and stare at that enormous amount of water, hearing the thundering sound of it crashing down. The sound of His voice is like rushing water"* (see Revelation 1:15). To behold, she says, is *"to give your full attention. You don't want anything to keep you from taking in the moment."*



The Vanderkloof Dam: “His voice was like the roar of many waters.”

Gazing is not yet beholding. You can gaze without beholding. You can stare at a page of your Bible for ten minutes and see nothing, because your mind is somewhere else. Beholding is when your eyes and your heart arrive, and you actually see Him. Even that seeing is a gift we ask for: *"Open my eyes, that I may behold wondrous things out of your law"* (Psalm 119:18). The English word helps: *be-hold* means to hold something in view and keep holding it. As Ryan Kingsley puts it: "Behold: hold in your view, hold in your gaze."

Beholding is when your eyes and your heart arrive, and you actually see Him.

Beholding is a relationship, not a ritual. It is not glancing, and it is not analysing. We do not look at Jesus to collect information about Him, but to know Him. It is a

deliberate focus: in a world full of distractions, we choose to fix our eyes on Him (Hebrews 12:2).



“One thing have I asked of the LORD… to gaze upon the beauty of the LORD” (Psalm 27:4)

One thing. David was a king with a hundred and one things on his mind: decisions, people to lead, wars to fight. And yet he wrote: *"One thing have I asked of the LORD, that will I seek after: that I may dwell in the house of the LORD all the days of my life, to gaze upon the beauty of the LORD"* (Psalm 27:4). The word for beauty is *no'am*: delightfulness, loveliness, the kind of beauty that makes you linger because you can't look away. Not many things. One thing: a Person worth gazing at forever.

The mirror of 2 Corinthians 3:18. Paul writes that we are *"beholding the glory of the Lord"*. The Greek word, *katoptrizomenoi*, comes from the word for a mirror. It can mean "beholding as in a mirror" and also "reflecting like a mirror". Both are true at once: we look at His glory, and as we look, we begin to reflect it.



A bronze mirror makes no light of its own; it can only reflect it.

In Paul's day there were no glass mirrors. Mirrors were made of polished metal, usually bronze, and Corinth was famous for its bronze. Such a mirror never made its own light; it could only reflect light that fell on it. That is the picture: we have no light of our own, but turned toward Him, we catch His light and send it on.

The world's mirror tells you how *you* look and asks you to improve yourself. In the kingdom of God, the mirror shows you *Him*. When we look into it, we stop being busy with ourselves.

We have no light of our own, but turned toward Him, we catch His light and send it on.

Moses and the veil. When Moses came down the mountain after speaking with God, his face shone, and the people were afraid to come near him. He put a veil over his face (Exodus 34:29–35). Paul says a veil still lies over hearts that do not see Christ, *"but when one turns to the Lord, the veil is removed"* (2 Corinthians 3:16). In Christ we look at His glory with *"unveiled face"* (3:18). The Greek tense means the veil was taken away and stays away.

In short. To behold is more than to glance or even to gaze: it is to look with the eyes and the heart until we truly see Him. In Christ the veil is removed, and like a mirror we both see His glory and begin to reflect it.

Supporting verses: Psalm 27:4 · Psalm 119:18 · Hebrews 12:2 · Revelation 1:15 · 2 Corinthians 3:7–18 · Exodus 34:29–35 · 1 Corinthians 13:12 · James 1:23–25

3 Jesus, the perfect image of the Father

The question behind every question. If we become what we behold, then everything depends on *what God is really like*. No one can look directly at God. *"No one has ever seen God; the only God, who is at the Father's side, he has made him known"* (John 1:18). The word for "made him known" is the root of our word *exegesis*: Jesus is the explanation of God. When we want to know what God is like, we look at Jesus.

"Whoever has seen me has seen the Father." Philip once asked Jesus: "Lord, show us the Father, and it is enough for us." Jesus answered: *"Have I been with you so long, and you still do not know me, Philip? Whoever has seen me has seen the Father"* (John 14:8–9). And again: *"Whoever sees me sees him who sent me"* (John 12:45). Paul calls Him *"the image of the invisible God"* (Colossians 1:15), and says God has shone in our hearts *"to give the light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Jesus Christ"* (2 Corinthians 4:6). God's glory has a face, and it is the face of Jesus.

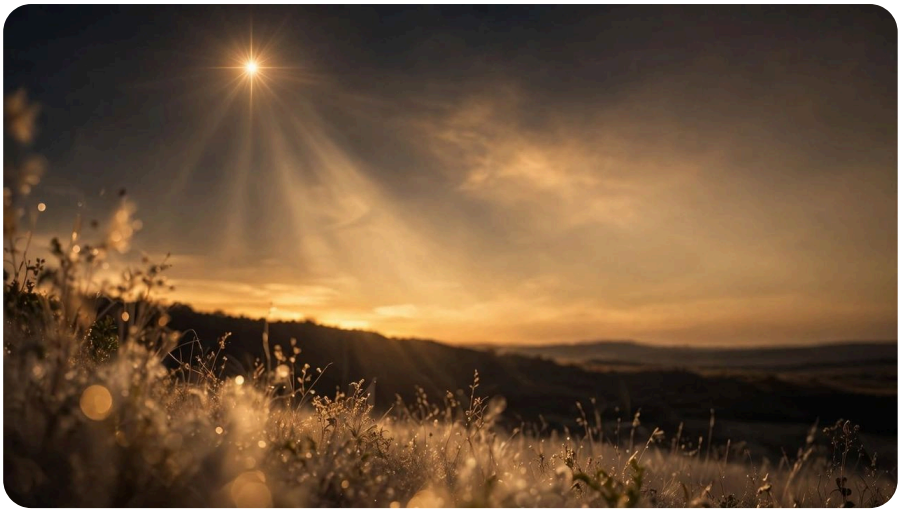


"He is the radiance of the glory of God" (Hebrews 1:3)

Radiance and exact imprint. Hebrews says: *"He is the radiance of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature"* (Hebrews 1:3). Two pictures:

- **Radiance** (*apaugasma*): the shining-out of light from its source, like sunlight from the sun. You can't have the sun without its light. Jesus is not a lamp lit from outside; He is the light of God shining out. The early church confessed Him as "Light from Light, true God from true God" (Nicene Creed).
- **Exact imprint** (*charaktēr*): the mark a seal or stamp leaves in wax or metal. Every line of the stamp shows in the impression. Everything God is, is seen in Jesus.

Not borrowed light. This matters when we compare Jesus with Lucifer later (section 6). Ezekiel 28:12 describes the fallen one as *"the signet of perfection"*: a created seal, made to show God's likeness to creation. His light was borrowed: he was made to catch God's light and reflect it, like a gem. Jesus is different in kind. He is not a creature given the job of showing God; He *is* God, the exact imprint by nature. Lucifer had borrowed light and tried to keep it. Jesus has His own light and gives all the glory to the Father.



"I am… the bright morning star" (Revelation 22:16)

> *"Whoever has seen me has seen the Father."*
>
> **JOHN 14:9**

The bright Morning Star. On the last page of the Bible Jesus says: *"I am the root and the descendant of David, the bright morning star"* (Revelation 22:16). The morning star is the planet Venus, the brightest light in the sky just before sunrise. It tells you the night is almost over and the day is coming. (Venus shines by reflecting the sun. That fits us, not Jesus: He is the light itself. The picture fits Jesus as the herald of the new day.) Isaiah called the fallen one *"Day Star, son of Dawn"* (Isaiah 14:12); he lost that place. Jesus is the true Morning Star. And Peter tells us to hold on to God's word *"until the day dawns and the morning star rises in your hearts"* (2 Peter 1:19). That is what beholding does: the Morning Star rises in us.

The centre of Scripture. Paul Washer: *"Always remember the main purpose of this book: it is to show us Christ, because in Christ we have the greatest display of the person, the glory, the beauty, and the excellencies of God."* Jesus Himself said the Scriptures *"bear witness about me"* (John 5:39). And Washer's reminder: "Jesus is all we need, but also Jesus is all we have."

In short. We cannot see God directly, but we can see Him perfectly in Jesus. Jesus is not a reflector of borrowed light; He is the radiance of God's glory and the exact imprint of His nature. To behold Jesus is to behold the Father.

Supporting verses: John 1:14, 18 · John 14:8–9 · John 12:45 · Colossians 1:15–19 · 2 Corinthians 4:4–6 · Hebrews 1:1–3 · Revelation 22:16 · 2 Peter 1:19 · John 5:39

4 What that image looks like

If Jesus shows us the Father, what do we actually see when we look at Him? One question helps: when you look at Jesus, do you see only a miracle-worker, or do you see a Son who loves His Father with His whole heart?

He lives for the Father's glory. At the end of His life Jesus prayed: *"I glorified you on earth, having accomplished the work that you gave me to do"* (John 17:4). He said: *"I do not seek my own glory"* (John 8:50). Everything He did pointed away from Himself to the Father.

He depends on the Father. *"The Son can do nothing of his own accord, but only what he sees the Father doing"* (John 5:19). Notice the words: "what he *sees* the Father doing". Jesus Himself lived by beholding.

He is humble and comes down. Paul writes:

> *"Have this mind among yourselves, which is yours in Christ Jesus, who, though he was in the form of God, did not count equality with God a thing to be grasped, but emptied himself, by taking the form of a servant, being born in the likeness of men. And being found in human form, he humbled himself by becoming obedient to the point of death, even death on a cross."*
> (Philippians 2:5–8)

The only time Jesus describes His own heart, He says: *"I am gentle and lowly in heart"* (Matthew 11:29). Andrew Selley sums it up: "The heart of God is to go down. The heart of Satan and man is to go up."



The King of kings kneels with a towel (John 13:4–5)

He serves. *"For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many"* (Mark 10:45). On the night before the cross, knowing that the Father had given all things into His hands, He got up from the table, took off His outer robe, wrapped a towel around His waist, poured water into a basin, and washed His disciples' feet (John 13:3–5). Every pair of feet, including those of Judas, who would betray Him that same night.



“Not my will, but yours, be done” (Luke 22:42)

He obeys, even when it costs everything. In Gethsemane, in agony, He prayed: *"Father, if you are willing, remove this cup from me. Nevertheless, not my will, but yours, be done"* (Luke 22:42).



“Lucifer's beauty went to his head. Jesus' beauty went to a cross.”

He gives His beauty away. Isaiah wrote of Him: *"He had no form or majesty that we should look at him, and no beauty that we should desire him"* (Isaiah 53:2); and at the cross *"his appearance was so marred, beyond human semblance"* (Isaiah 52:14). Andrew Selley: "Lucifer's beauty went to his head. Jesus' beauty went to a cross." Paul Washer calls the cross "the epicenter of all revelation": there we see God's holiness and mercy, justice and love, all at once.



The risen King, mistaken for a gardener (John 20:15)

He doesn't need to be noticed. On resurrection morning, having defeated death, He stands in a garden, and Mary thinks He is the gardener (John 20:15). The risen King of the universe, mistaken for a gardener.

“Lucifer's beauty went to his head. Jesus' beauty went to a cross.”

ANDREW SELLEY

The whole Trinity points away from itself. The Spirit points to the Son: *"He will glorify me"* (John 16:14). The Son points to the Father. And at the very end, when all things are under His feet, *"the Son himself will also be subjected to him who put all things in subjection under him, that God may be all in all"* (1 Corinthians 15:28). This is what God is like: equal in glory, and glad to give glory away.

Humility: the soil the fruit grows in. Humility is not named in the list of the fruit of the Spirit in Galatians 5:22–23, though gentleness comes close. But it is the soil the fruit grows in. Paul puts it right among them: *"Put on then, as God's chosen ones, holy and beloved, compassionate hearts, kindness, humility, meekness, and patience"* (Colossians 3:12). Humility is at the root of who Jesus is and who God is. Beholding Jesus' humility grows humility in us, and humility makes room for every other fruit.

A test for every day. Andrew Selley gives a simple question to discern what is behind anything we see or do: *"Is it trying to go up, or trying to go down?"* Up is the way of the fallen one. Down is the way of Jesus.

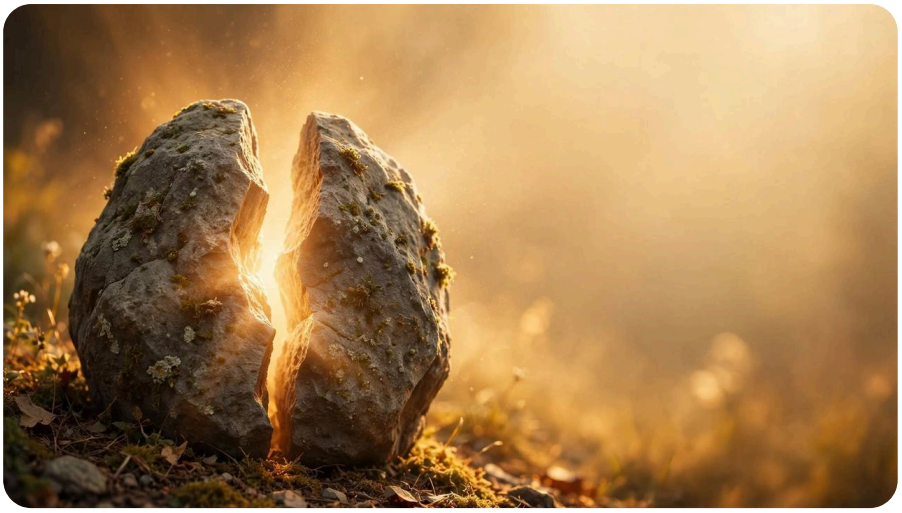
In short. In Jesus we see a God who lives for the Father's glory, depends on Him, humbles Himself, serves, obeys and gives His beauty away. This is the image we are being changed into, and humility is its root.

Supporting verses: John 17:4 · John 8:50 · John 5:19 · Philippians 2:5–11 · Matthew 11:29 · Mark 10:45 · John 13:1–17 · Luke 22:42 · Isaiah 52:14; 53:2 · John 20:15 · John 16:14 · 1 Corinthians 15:28 · Colossians 3:12 · Galatians 5:22–23

Part B — What happens to those who look

God has called, and He has shown us His face in Jesus. Now we ask what happens in the people who turn and look: how they change, what can go wrong, how we keep looking, and what God builds out of those who do.

5 From stone to flesh: changed by looking



"I will remove the heart of stone… and give you a heart of flesh" (Ezekiel 36:26)

A heart of stone cannot behold. A stone has no eyes, no hunger and no light. It cannot respond to anything. That is how the Bible describes the human heart without God. But God promises: *"I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. And I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh. And I will put my Spirit within you"* (Ezekiel 36:26–27). A heart of flesh is soft, alive and able to see. This is where beholding becomes possible.

Living stones. That is why Peter calls us *living* stones (1 Peter 2:5). An ordinary stone can't choose, turn or yield. A living stone can. God does not force a stone into His wall; He makes it alive and invites it to lie still in His hands.

Hunger is the first sign of life. A dead stone wants nothing. The first sign that God has made a heart alive is that it gets hungry. *"Blessed are those who hunger and thirst for righteousness, for they shall be filled"* (Matthew 5:6). That hunger grows as we learn to be led (by God, by leaders and by fellow believers), to sacrifice and die to self as Jesus carried the cross, and to bow to nothing except God.

We become what we behold. Everyone is being shaped. As Annemarie puts it: *"The question is not IF you are being shaped, but BY WHAT you are being shaped."* John Piper says: "You become most like what you admire most." Think of teenagers and their heroes: a music star, an actor, a sports player. They watch every move, copy the hairstyle, the clothes, the way of speaking. Nobody tells them to; admiration does it. We are made that way. The Bible says the same thing about idols: *"Those who make them become like them"* (Psalm 115:8). And about Jesus: *"beholding the*

glory of the Lord, we are being transformed into the same image" (2 Corinthians 3:18).

Sight, not effort. Annemarie: *"Maybe you've started deleting social media apps from your phone, opening the Bible app first, praying every day, reading your Bible, tithing, doing good to others, but you see nothing change. It's because transformation begins with sight, not effort. You can't work yourself into being changed; you need to look at Christ until His beauty remakes you."*

Piper says seeing and changing are not two steps: "Beholding the glory of the Lord transforms us by satisfying us with his beauty and worth." Paul Washer: *"We grow in conformity to Christ and in devotion to Christ by seeing more and more of Christ."* And: *"God's people are not driven to conformity with a whip. They are shown the beauty of Christ… and they will chase after Christ themselves."* Ryan Kingsley: "If you want to become, you have to behold. If you want to imitate, you have to contemplate. If you want transformation, you need revelation."

Change begins with sight, not effort.

It is a little like standing in the sun. You don't try to get a tan; it happens because you stay in the light.

The Spirit does it. In 2 Corinthians 3:18 the verb *"are being transformed"* (*metamorphoumetha*) is passive and ongoing: it is done *to* us, and it keeps happening. *"For this comes from the Lord who is the Spirit."* Beholding is not a technique that produces power. It puts us where the Spirit works. Romans 8:29 says God has *"predestined \[us\] to be conformed to the image of his Son"*. As Ryan Kingsley says, "He did not predestine you to try hard enough to become better; He is the most active participant."



“His face shone like the sun” (Matthew 17:2)

The same verb appears in two other places. At the Transfiguration, Jesus *"was transfigured before them, and his face shone like the sun"* (Matthew 17:2). And in Romans 12:2: *"Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewal of your mind."* What happened to Jesus' face on the mountain begins to happen in us, from the inside.

From one degree of glory to another. Change is gradual. Andrew Selley, after about forty years of following Jesus: "I am still being transformed. God is continually taking us from one degree of glory to another." His question for every believer: *"Are you still changing?"*

What are we becoming? Not a better version of ourselves, but more like Jesus. We are being restored to what we were made for: image-bearers who show what God is like (Genesis 1:27; Colossians 3:10). *"We know that when he appears we shall be like him, because we shall see him as he is"* (1 John 3:2). In daily life it looks like this, in Ryan Kingsley's words: "Do I love more? Am I kinder, more patient, and more caring? Am I giving myself more to Jesus and His people?"

In short. God gives us a heart of flesh that can see and hunger. As we behold Jesus, the Spirit changes us into His image, slowly and surely, from glory to glory. Change begins with sight, not effort.

Supporting verses: Ezekiel 36:26–27 · 1 Peter 2:5 · Matthew 5:6 · Psalm 115:8 · 2 Corinthians 3:18 · Romans 8:29 · Matthew 17:2 · Romans 12:2 · Genesis 1:27 · Colossians 3:10 · 1 John 3:2 · Galatians 5:22–23

6 Three directions of beholding

We never stop beholding. People are made to worship. Our eyes are always resting on something, and whatever they rest on shapes us. Annemarie: *"We can stare at many things every day: our phones, our series, YouTube, other people, books, dirty kitchens. We can stare at nothing while our thoughts are churning over many things: worries, fears, anxiety, unfairness, hatred, envy."* And she asks: *"What are you doing when you're saying: Just wait a minute. Not now. Just let me finish this. Shhh!"*

There are really only three directions our gaze can take:

DIRECTION	WE LOOK AT	DRIVEN BY	WHERE IT LEADS
Up: God-beholding	Jesus, and the Father's glory	Worship, love, trust, obedience	Life, freedom, transformation into His image
In: self-beholding	My image, my success, my comfort, even my failures	Self-protection, self-glory, endless self-analysis	Pride when things go well, despair when they don't; either way, self is on the throne
Out: world-beholding	Money, status, pleasure, people's approval, career, screens	Trying to fill an emptiness only God can fill	Slavery: whatever we fix our eyes on becomes our master

Self-beholding: the fall of the morning star

A note on interpretation: Ezekiel 28 is addressed to the king of Tyre and Isaiah 14 to the king of Babylon. Since the early church, many Bible teachers have seen behind these proud kings the first rebel, Satan, because the language goes beyond any human king (*"You were in Eden, the garden of God"*, Ezekiel 28:13). We follow that reading here, while holding the details lightly.



A gem that turns from the light goes dark.

Made to reflect. *"You were the signet of perfection, full of wisdom and perfect in beauty. You were in Eden, the garden of God; every precious stone was your covering"* (Ezekiel 28:12–13). Covered in precious stones, and a gem has no light of its own. Andrew Selley: "His whole purpose was to say: Look at Him. This is what He is like." His name, Lucifer, means "light-bearer".

He turned to look at himself. *"Your heart was proud because of your beauty; you corrupted your wisdom for the sake of your splendour"* (Ezekiel 28:17). Andrew Selley: "It was not ultimately his own beauty; it was the beauty of the One he was called to reflect." He wanted to be the destination of the light, not the reflector of it. Isaiah records five "I wills" (Isaiah 14:13–14):

1. "I will ascend to heaven."
2. "Above the stars of God I will set my throne on high."
3. "I will sit on the mount of assembly."
4. "I will ascend above the heights of the clouds."
5. "I will make myself like the Most High."

What happens to a gem that turns from the light? It goes dark. The light-bearer became Satan, the accuser. And in Eden he offered humanity the same temptation: *"You will be like God"* (Genesis 3:5).

	LUCIFER: SELF-GLORY	JESUS: THE FATHER'S GLORY
Focus	"Look at my beauty and my throne."	"I do not seek my own glory" (John 8:50)

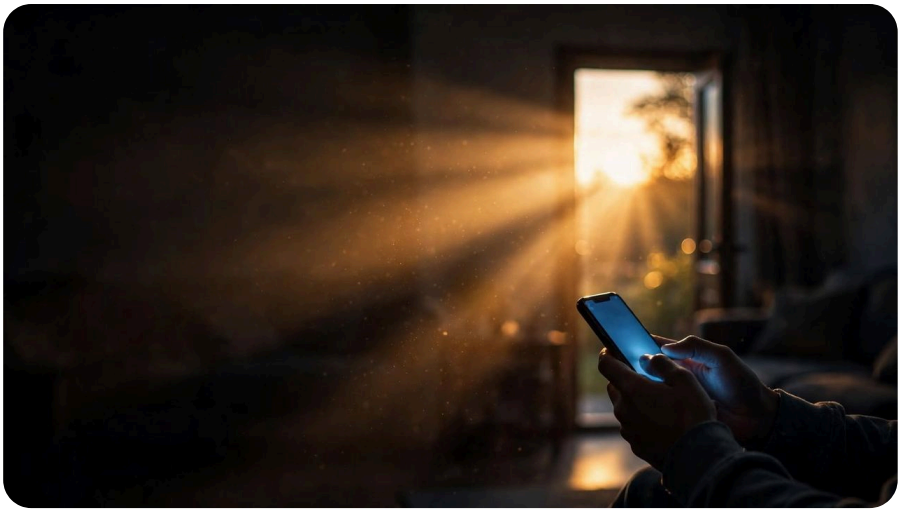
	LUCIFER: SELF-GLORY	JESUS: THE FATHER'S GLORY
Motto	"I will make myself like the Most High."	"The Son can do nothing of his own accord" (John 5:19)
His will	"I will"	"Not my will, but yours" (Luke 22:42)
Direction	Up	Down
Message	"Notice me."	"Notice the Father."
End	Cast down (Isaiah 14:15)	Highly exalted (Philippians 2:9)

A gem that turns from the light goes dark.

The trap for believers. Self-beholding is not only for the obviously proud. When we start admiring our own ministry, our good deeds, our knowledge or our spiritual progress, we walk into the same trap, using God's gifts to draw attention to ourselves. Andrew Selley warns: "If you desire influence, I pray you never get it until you desire only to reflect Him." The other side of self-beholding is constant self-criticism: "I'm not good enough." It looks humble, but the eyes are still on self.

The cure. Humility is not thinking badly of yourself; it is thinking of yourself less, because your eyes are full of Someone else. The more we look at Jesus, the more we are healed from the need to "be someone". We become like a clean window: hardly noticed, so that His light shines clearly through.

World-beholding: life under the sun



What we stare at shapes us.

Idols make us like them. *"Their idols are silver and gold, the work of human hands. They have mouths, but do not speak; eyes, but do not see… Those who make them become like them; so do all who trust in them"* (Psalm 115:4–8). Fix your eyes on money and you become greedy. Fix them on people's approval and you become a slave to their opinions. Romans 1:21–23 traces the slide: people stopped giving God glory, their thinking became futile, and they *"exchanged the glory of the immortal God for images"* of created things.

Ecclesiastes: the great experiment. The Preacher keeps saying "I saw…". He looked at everything under the sun: pleasure, wealth, building projects, wisdom, reputation (Ecclesiastes 2:1–10). His verdict: *"Behold, all was vanity and a striving after wind, and there was nothing to be gained under the sun"* (2:11). *"The eye is not satisfied with seeing"* (1:8). *"The eyes of man are never satisfied"* (Proverbs 27:20). God's sad word through Jeremiah fits: *"They have forsaken me, the fountain of living waters, and hewed out cisterns for themselves, broken cisterns that can hold no water"* (Jeremiah 2:13).

Looking at life under the sun leaves us empty. Looking at the One above the sun satisfies: *"As for me, I shall behold your face in righteousness; when I awake, I shall be satisfied with your likeness"* (Psalm 17:15).

Two sides of one coin. Self-beholding and world-beholding belong together. When we stop beholding God, we either stare into the mirror at ourselves, or we chase the world to make the self happy. Jesus calls us to take our eyes off both and fix them on Him. When we behold Him, the idols fall away because He is more beautiful, and the self finds rest because He has already done everything.

In short. Our eyes always rest somewhere: on God, on ourselves or on the world. Self-beholding led the morning star to fall, and world-beholding leaves us empty under the sun. Only beholding God satisfies and frees us.

Supporting verses: Ezekiel 28:12–17 · Isaiah 14:12–15 · Genesis 3:5 · Psalm 115:4–8 · Romans 1:21–23 · Ecclesiastes 1:8; 2:1–11 · Proverbs 27:20 · Jeremiah 2:13 · Psalm 17:15 · John 8:50 · Philippians 2:9 · Hebrews 12:2

7 Wrong ways of beholding Jesus

It is possible to look in Jesus' direction and still not behold Him. Believers easily slip into a wrong picture of beholding, usually when our relationship with God shifts from *who He is* to *what He can do for us*.

A Jesus of our own making. Andrew Selley quotes an old saying: "In the beginning God made man in His image, and mankind decided to return the favour." We easily build a Jesus who looks like us and wants what we want. Paul Washer warns: *"There is a Jesus out there — or rather, many different things are called Jesus that are not Jesus."* We must behold *"the Christ that is defined in the Scriptures … not a Christ according to some carnal desire, not a Christ according to a certain flavour of culture, but a biblical Christ"*: in His love and His holiness, His mercy and His righteousness, His power to save and His authority to judge.

Three common misunderstandings

1. **The wish-list Jesus (the consumer).** Prayer becomes a transaction: we come to God with our needs, fears and wishes so that He can fix our circumstances. Instead of looking at Jesus, we look at our list. God becomes a means to an end (a more comfortable life) rather than the end Himself. Many people behold Jesus only for the ways He can serve them.
2. **The self-mirror.** We look toward God, but really use Him as a mirror to look at ourselves: either to see how well we are doing (pride) or to analyse our failures endlessly (guilt and condemnation). Both are still about me. When you truly look at Jesus, you stop measuring yourself; you are caught up in His beauty.
3. **Information without intimacy (the student).** We read and study about Jesus without ever worshipping Him. Jesus said this to the religious experts of His day: *"You search the Scriptures because you think that in them you have eternal life; and it is they that bear witness about me, yet you refuse to come to me that*

you may have life" (John 5:39–40). Collecting facts about Jesus is not the same as beholding Him.

Why it matters. A wish-list does not change the heart; only beholding His glory does (2 Corinthians 3:18). If God's main job in our eyes is to answer requests, our faith will dry up when He says "no" or "wait". But if our eyes are on Him, our faith stands firm, because He never changes. And we miss Jesus' own example: His life was aimed at the Father's glory, not His own comfort.

We behold Jesus because He is worth beholding.

Hand or face? This does not mean we may never ask God for anything. Jesus taught us to pray, *"Give us this day our daily bread"* (Matthew 6:11). But notice the order: the prayer begins with *"Our Father in heaven, hallowed be your name"* (6:9). It is about order and weight.

WRONG BEHOLDING	TRUE BEHOLDING
Starts with me: "Lord, here is my need, my fear, my plan."	Starts with Him: "Lord, You are holy, faithful, good and mighty."
Aim: to get God to do my will on earth	Aim: to be so filled with Jesus that my will changes to His
Focus: what God's hand can give	Focus: who God's face is (Psalm 27:8; 105:4)
Result: short relief, or ongoing anxiety	Result: lasting change of character, becoming like Christ

A picture. When you watch a beautiful sunset, you don't bring it a list of demands. You simply stand still and admire it. And while you admire it, its light changes the colour of your face. When we come to Jesus, our first priority is to stand and look at who He is. When our eyes are full of Him, our needs either dissolve in His presence or line up with the Father's will.

Fruit or motive? Ryan Kingsley tells how people who came regularly to their Monday-night "Behold" evenings saw their marriages, families and struggles improve. Paul Washer warns against serving God "because He fixed my marriage

… because He blessed my children", and says: *"You're missing the point. Just to be able to see Him as He is — His excellencies, His holiness, His righteousness, His grace."* Both are true. Good fruit follows beholding, but it is not the reason we look. We behold Jesus because He is worth beholding.

Isaac Ambrose (Puritan, *Looking Unto Jesus*, 1658), read by Paul Washer: *"A right beholding of Christ in His eternal workings will cause a desire of Christ above all desires. The heart now thirsts for nothing but Him … all power, all love, all holiness, all happiness. Tell such a soul of the world, gold, and glory. Oh, but what are these? … 'Give me God in Christ,' says the soul, 'or I die.'"* (see Philippians 3:8).

In short. We can look toward Jesus and still miss Him: by making Him a vending machine, a mirror for ourselves, or a subject to study. True beholding seeks His face, not only His hand, and looks at the Christ the Scriptures show us.

Supporting verses: John 5:39–40 · Matthew 6:9–11 · Psalm 27:8 · Psalm 105:4 · Philippians 3:7–10 · 2 Corinthians 3:18 · 2 Corinthians 11:4 · Psalm 119:18

8 How we behold today

First, a guard. What follows are not new rules. Annemarie puts it well: these things don't change us; only Jesus changes us. They simply put us where He can. And remember: He looked at us first (Mark 10:21).

Fix your eyes, look away. *"Let us run with endurance the race that is set before us, looking to Jesus, the founder and perfecter of our faith"* (Hebrews 12:1–2). The Greek word (*aphorōntes*) means "looking away from other things, to Him". Peter walked on water while he looked at Jesus; when he *"saw the wind"*, he began to sink (Matthew 14:29–30). David wrote: *"I have set the LORD always before me; because he is at my right hand, I shall not be shaken"* (Psalm 16:8).

Jesus is not walking our streets in a body today, so how do we look at Him?

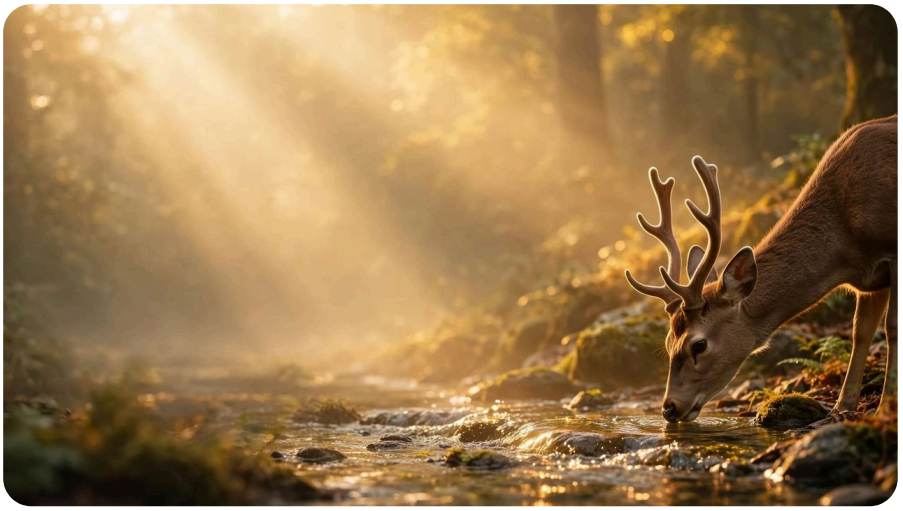
1. Through the Word. The Scriptures are where we see Him clearly. The Old Testament points to Him and the New Testament reveals Him; on the road to Emmaus, Jesus explained *"in all the Scriptures the things concerning himself"* (Luke 24:27). Read not only for information or rules, but asking: *What does this show me of Jesus: His grace, His humility, His obedience to the Father?* Read the Gospels slowly. *"Open my eyes, that I may behold"* (Psalm 119:18).

2. Through prayer, worship and communion. Slow down. Sit before the Lord without a long list, and think about who He is: His faithfulness, His cross, His resurrection. Let your heart admire and worship Him. *"Be still, and know that I am God"* (Psalm 46:10). Ryan Kingsley's church began "Behold" evenings: worship and breaking bread around a communion table, with no agenda. "Whenever we tried to turn it into an agenda, it lost life. The whole point was just to see Jesus." In communion we *"proclaim the Lord's death until he comes"* (1 Corinthians 11:26): we look again at the Lamb.

3. Through the Holy Spirit. Jesus said of the Spirit: *"He will glorify me, for he will take what is mine and declare it to you"* (John 16:14). The Spirit makes Jesus real to us and keeps turning our thoughts back to Him.

4. Through one another. *"No one has ever seen God; if we love one another, God abides in us and his love is perfected in us"* (1 John 4:12). When believers serve, forgive and show grace to each other, we see something of Jesus in and through each other.

5. In the hard moments. Beholding is not only for quiet times. In a difficult conversation, at work, at home, we can stop and ask: *How does Jesus see this person? Is this going up, or going down?*



“As a deer pants for flowing streams, so pants my soul for you, O God” (Psalm 42:1)

Annemarie's four practices

1. We come hungry. *"Blessed are those who hunger and thirst for righteousness, for they shall be filled"* (Matthew 5:6). Annemarie: *"People can hear the same Word and walk away differently. The difference isn't access, it's appetite."* Blind Bartimaeus refused to be silenced and kept shouting for Jesus (Mark 10:46–52).

The woman who had been bleeding for twelve years pressed through the crowd to touch His clothes (Mark 5:25–34). *"As a deer pants for flowing streams, so pants my soul for you, O God"* (Psalm 42:1). Her question: *"Do you long to be changed?"*



She pressed through the crowd just to touch His clothes
(Mark 5:27–28)

2. We fix our eyes on what is true. *"The blessed man of Psalm 1 doesn't occasionally glance at the Word of God; he meditates on the Word day and night"* (Psalm 1:2). And we carry the Word with us, like Mary, who *"treasured up all these things, pondering them in her heart"* (Luke 2:19). *"If you abide in my word, you are truly my disciples, and you will know the truth, and the truth will set you free"* (John 8:31–32).

3. We take thoughts captive. *"The battle is at the level of your attention."* Notice what doesn't line up with God's Word and choose not to rehearse it (*"take every thought captive to obey Christ"*, 2 Corinthians 10:5), and let God transform you by changing the way you think (Romans 12:2). Annemarie: *"Distraction redirects your gaze. It's dangerous because it's constant. You may not be resisting God, just inattentive, your attention too fragmented for truth to settle."*



“His delight is in the law of the LORD” (Psalm 1:2)

4. We stay long enough. *"We become what we revisit, not what we hear once."* *"Whatever is true, whatever is honourable, whatever is just, whatever is pure, whatever is lovely… think about these things"* (Philippians 4:8). Her picture: an ice cube lasts for weeks in the freezer but disappears in the sun. It's not the ice cube that decides how long it lasts; it's where it stays. And James describes someone who looks in a mirror, walks away and at once forgets what he looks like (James 1:23–24). *"The problem wasn't sight but duration."*

The gaze that never ends. Annemarie: *"Beholding ends where David longed to be: 'they will see his face' (Revelation 22:4). Until then, don't glance; gaze on how beautiful your God is in Jesus, and let the looking begin to change you."*

In short. We behold Jesus today through the Word, prayer and worship, the Spirit and one another, and in the middle of ordinary days. We come hungry, fix our eyes on what is true, guard our attention and stay long enough. These practices don't change us; they put us where He can.

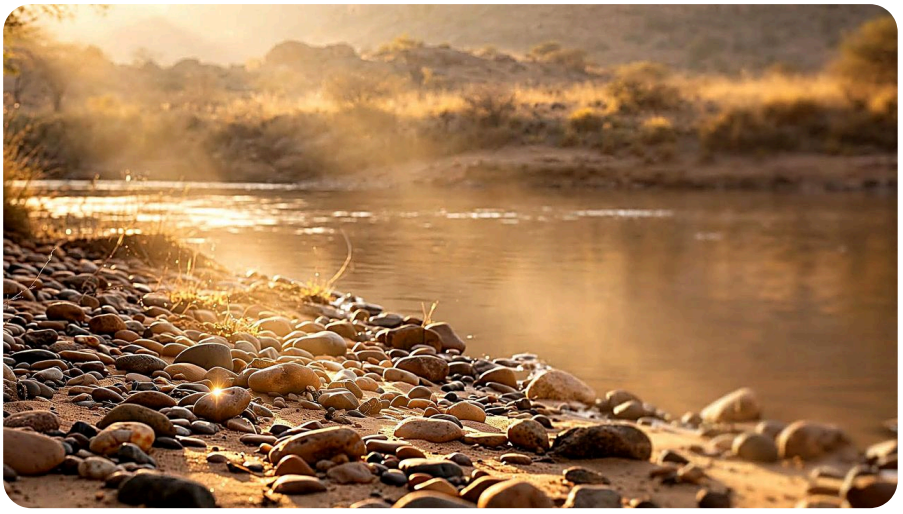
Supporting verses: Hebrews 12:1–3 · Matthew 14:29–30 · Psalm 16:8 · Luke 24:27 · Psalm 119:18 · Psalm 46:10 · 1 Corinthians 11:26 · John 16:14 · 1 John 4:12 · Matthew 5:6 · Psalm 42:1 · Psalm 1:2 · Luke 2:19 · John 8:31–32 · 2 Corinthians 10:5 · Romans 12:2 · Philippians 4:8 · James 1:23–25 · Revelation 22:4

9 Built in together

"We all." Our key verse begins: *"And we all…"* (2 Corinthians 3:18). Not "I". God does not change us only for our own private spiritual journey. He builds us in. Many people today think: "Me and Jesus are fine; I don't need the church." But you

cannot become like Jesus, who loved the church and gave Himself for her (Ephesians 5:25), without wanting to be part of His body. Beholding always leads us to one another.

God builds differently. *"The stone that the builders rejected has become the cornerstone"* (Psalm 118:22). Jesus Himself was the rejected stone. And the One who was overlooked is the One who picks up the overlooked: *"God chose what is low and despised in the world"* (1 Corinthians 1:26–28). *"As you come to him, a living stone rejected by men but in the sight of God chosen and precious, you yourselves like living stones are being built up as a spiritual house"* (1 Peter 2:4–5). *"In him you also are being built together into a dwelling place for God by the Spirit"* (Ephesians 2:22).



The banks of the Orange River, near Hopetown

A pebble on the riverbank. In 1867, near Hopetown on the banks of the Orange River, not far from the Vanderkloof Dam, fifteen-year-old Erasmus Jacobs picked up a stone that looked like a pebble. Nobody knew what it was; it was later sent off in an ordinary paper envelope to be identified. It was the Eureka Diamond, the first diamond found in South Africa. It now lies in the Mine Museum in Kimberley, down the road from us. That is how we look when God finds us: a dull stone that others walk past. God sees what is hidden inside.



A diamond has no light of its own.

No light of its own. A diamond in a dark room is completely dark. It has no light of its own; all its beauty depends on catching light and sending it back. We too shine only when we are turned toward Him.



Half of the Eureka was cut away so it could catch the light.

Cut to shine. A rough diamond cannot sparkle. It has to be cut, and each face (facet) is cut at an exact angle so that light entering the stone bounces back out. The Eureka weighed 21.25 carats rough and 10.73 carats after cutting: half of it was cut away so it could catch the light. Our lives are cut too. Every time we choose forgiveness over offence, humility over pride, His will over our own, something rough is ground away and a new facet catches His light. Offence is one of the corners the Master cuts away. *"Clothe yourselves, all of you, with humility toward one another… Humble yourselves, therefore, under the mighty hand of God"* (1 Peter 5:5–6). Andrew Selley calls this a teachable spirit: people who "remain teachable and work things through with their leaders rather than becoming offended and shutting down."

The jewels of a crown. In 1905 the Cullinan Diamond, the largest gem-quality rough diamond ever found (3,106 carats), was found at the Premier Mine near Pretoria. (A story often told says the manager who found it first thought it was a piece of glass.) It was cut into many stones, and the two largest, the Great Star of Africa and the Second Star of Africa, now sit in the British Crown Jewels, in the Sovereign's Sceptre and the Imperial State Crown. Zechariah wrote of God's people: *"Like the jewels of a crown they shall shine on his land"* (Zechariah 9:16). And Malachi: *"They shall be mine, saith the LORD of hosts, in that day when I make up my jewels"* (Malachi 3:17, KJV).



The wall in our church building in Boshof

Lined up on the Cornerstone, not the neighbour. One day Jurie looked at the stone wall in our church building and said: "Not every stone in that wall is straight. Some are crooked." When I measure myself against the stone next to me, all I see are its crooked edges. Jesus asked: *"Why do you see the speck that is in your brother's eye, but do not notice the log that is in your own eye?"* (Matthew 7:3). When I turn to the Cornerstone, I see my own crooked edges first, and His grace for both of us. *"Behold, I am laying in Zion a stone, a cornerstone chosen and precious"* (1 Peter 2:6). A builder lines a stone up with the cornerstone, not with the stone beside it; God measures with His own plumb line (Amos 7:7–8). The answer is not to stare harder at myself, but to turn back to the light.

Consider Jesus, then one another. Hebrews uses the same word twice: *"Consider Jesus"* (3:1), and later, *"Let us consider how to stir up one another to love and good works, not neglecting to meet together"* (10:24–25). The word (*katanoeō*) is also the word for "notice" in Matthew 7:3. First we consider Jesus. Then we consider one another. In that order.

We don't become one by staring at each other; we become one when each of us bows to Jesus.

Unity comes from looking at Jesus. Ryan Kingsley: "Unity does not come merely through better communication, fellowship, food, clearer vision, or shared goals. Unity comes when we see Jesus." When we see the King of kings kneeling with a towel, we lose our excuses for jostling for position. We grow in unity as we become more like Christ.

The tuning fork. A.W. Tozer wrote in *The Pursuit of God* (1948): *"Has it ever occurred to you that one hundred pianos all tuned to the same fork are automatically tuned to each other? They are of one accord by being tuned, not to each other, but to another standard to which each one must individually bow."* An orchestra does the same before a concert: every instrument tunes to one note, usually played by the oboe. We don't become one by staring at each other; we become one when each of us bows to Jesus.

Many colours of one light. When light enters a cut diamond, it breaks into all the colours of the rainbow. Paul says that through the church *"the manifold wisdom of God"* is made known (Ephesians 3:10). *Manifold* (*polypoikilos*) means many-coloured. Each of us reflects a different colour of His glory, using the gifts of His *"varied grace"* (1 Peter 4:10). Beholding Jesus doesn't make us all the same. It makes us all His, each shining His light in our own colour, and we need each other to show the full picture.

Come to give, not to get. Andrew Selley: "Our people come to church to love. They don't come to get; they come to give … Unless these values are worked into us, people will come for the show … That is a consumer base, not a Christ base." *"Love one another: just as I have loved you, you also are to love one another"* (John 13:34).

God sets the lonely in families. *"God settles the solitary in a home"* (Psalm 68:6). A loose stone lying alone in the mud is lonely and fragile; it has no protection and no purpose. God doesn't only save us from sin; He gives us a home. He takes the lonely, the loners and the broken and builds them into a spiritual family, where they find protection, support and belonging. There is hope here for every

"damaged stone": just as Jesus was the rejected stone that became the Cornerstone, God takes broken stones and gives them a precious place in His wall.

In short. Beholding leads us to one another. God picks up overlooked stones, cuts away what blocks His light, lines us up on Jesus the Cornerstone rather than on each other, and sets us side by side: many colours of one light, a family where the lonely belong.

Supporting verses: 2 Corinthians 3:18 · Ephesians 5:25 · Psalm 118:22 · 1 Corinthians 1:26–28 · 1 Peter 2:4–7 · Ephesians 2:19–22 · 1 Peter 5:5–6 · Zechariah 9:16 · Malachi 3:17 · Matthew 7:3–5 · Amos 7:7–8 · Hebrews 3:1; 10:24–25 · Philippians 2:1–11 · John 13:34 · Ephesians 3:10 · 1 Peter 4:10 · Psalm 68:6

10 A wall of precious stones

Where it is all going. God promised His suffering people: *"O afflicted one, storm-tossed and not comforted, behold, I will set your stones in antimony, and lay your foundations with sapphires. I will make your pinnacles of agate, your gates of carbuncles, and all your wall of precious stones"* (Isaiah 54:11–12). God's answer to a storm-tossed, uncomforted people is to build them into something beautiful.



“Its lamp is the Lamb” (Revelation 21:23)

The city of God. At the end of the Bible, John is shown the holy city, *"having the glory of God, its radiance like a most rare jewel, like a jasper, clear as crystal"* (Revelation 21:11). *"The wall of the city had twelve foundations, and on them were the twelve names of the twelve apostles of the Lamb"* (21:14). *"The foundations of the wall of the city were adorned with every kind of jewel"* (21:19). And the light? *"The city has no need of sun or moon to shine on it, for the glory of God gives it*

light, and its lamp is the Lamb" (21:23). Every stone shines with a light that is not its own.

> “Its *lamp is the Lamb.*”
>
> REVELATION 21:23

The stones Lucifer lost. Remember the one who was covered with every precious stone (Ezekiel 28:13) and used his beauty to draw attention to himself. In God's new creation, His people become the precious stones, but without pride. We stand together in the wall so that the light of the Lamb breaks through us and fills everything with God's glory. **The stones Lucifer lost by looking at himself, God is building into a wall out of people who look at Jesus.**

Names on His heart. In the Old Testament, the high priest wore a breastpiece with twelve precious stones, each engraved with the name of one of the tribes of Israel (Exodus 28:17–21). *"So Aaron shall bear the names of the sons of Israel in the breastpiece of judgement on his heart, when he goes into the Holy Place"* (28:29). Andrew Selley notes the contrast: the fallen one's stones carried no names, because everything was about himself. The high priest carried the people's names.

Jesus is our great High Priest (Hebrews 4:14–16), and *"he always lives to make intercession"* for us (Hebrews 7:25). He carries us on His heart. And He says: *"Behold, I have engraved you on the palms of my hands"* (Isaiah 49:16). After His resurrection, He still carried the wounds and showed them to Thomas (John 20:27). Andrew Selley: "When we get to heaven, there will be no scars, except for one: the scars carried by Jesus." Right now, the God of the universe has your name written on His hands and prays for you by name.



“They will see his face” (Revelation 22:4)

His name on ours. Annemarie reminds us that beholding ends where David longed to be: *"They will see his face"* (Revelation 22:4). The verse continues: *"and his name will be on their foreheads."* He carries our names on His hands; in the end we carry His name, looking at His face. *"For now we see in a mirror dimly, but then face to face"* (1 Corinthians 13:12). *"We shall be like him, because we shall see him as he is"* (1 John 3:2).

A rehearsal for eternity. What we do now (loving one another, serving together, beholding Jesus) is a rehearsal for our eternal home. Every time a lonely stone is set into the wall, every time a believer turns from offence to forgiveness, every time the church gathers to look at Jesus, something of the New Jerusalem shines in Boshof today.

The Morning Star at dawn. Jesus, *"the bright morning star"* (Revelation 22:16), is the promise that the night is almost over. The day is coming when beholding will never end.

In short. God is building a city whose walls are precious stones, lit by the Lamb. Jesus our High Priest carries our names on His heart and hands, and one day we will see His face and carry His name. Every act of beholding now is a rehearsal for that day.

Supporting verses: Isaiah 54:11–12 · Revelation 21:10–27 · Ezekiel 28:13 · Exodus 28:15–30 · Hebrews 4:14–16 · Hebrews 7:25 · Isaiah 49:16 · John 20:27 · Revelation 22:1–5, 16 · 1 Corinthians 13:12 · 1 John 3:2

Closing summary and call

The whole story in a few lines. God calls hard-hearted people in mercy (section 1). He shows us His face in Jesus, the radiance of His glory and the exact imprint of His nature (sections 2–3). In Jesus we see a God who lives for the Father's glory, humbles Himself and serves (section 4). Those who turn and look receive hearts of flesh and are changed into His image, from glory to glory, by the Spirit (section 5). We can look the wrong way, at ourselves or at the world, or look at a Jesus of our own making (sections 6–7). But as we keep looking at Him through the Word, worship, the Spirit and one another (section 8), He cuts us, lines us up on the Cornerstone and builds us together (section 9) into a wall of precious stones that will shine with His light forever (section 10).

> God takes hearts as hard as stone and softens them by His Spirit, so that they can behold Jesus. Then He turns them into living gemstones. He doesn't leave us as loose stones on a pile. He builds us firmly on Jesus, the Cornerstone, so that when the world looks at the Church, it sees the reflected glory of the Father.

Take-away: Keep looking at Jesus. We become what we behold, and together we shine with His light.

Monday question: Is it going up, or going down?

Why would an ordinary person say yes to Jesus?

The world offers many shiny things: money, status, pleasure, approval and control. Why would anyone believe Jesus is more beautiful?

- **The world needs mercy.** The world runs on performance, comparison and condemnation, and when people fail, it walks over them. The law and judgement only make hearts harder. Only God's mercy, shown at the cross, can break a heart of stone and make it soft.
- **The world offers pleasure; Jesus offers belonging.** The world says: "Perform, look good, succeed, and then we'll accept you." Jesus says: "I carried you on My heart while you were still a sinner. I have engraved your name on My hands" (Romans 5:8; Isaiah 49:16). He sets the lonely in families (Psalm 68:6).

- **The world uses your beauty; Jesus makes you a gem.** The world uses people and throws them away, promising sparkle but leaving hearts empty and hard. Jesus, the rejected stone, takes rejected stones and makes them shine with His glory.
- **The world passes; Jesus gives an eternal place.** Moth and rust destroy everything under the sun (Matthew 6:19–20). Beholding Jesus gives not only a better life today, but a place in a wall that will stand forever.



“Turn to me and be saved, all the ends of the earth!” (Isaiah 45:22)

The call

> The world asks you to look at it and give your life for things that will leave you lonely and broken in the end.
>
> But look at Jesus today. Look at the High Priest who carries your name on His heart. Look at the hands your name is engraved on. He wants to lift you out of your loneliness, soften your heart of stone, and build you as a precious stone into His family.
>
> He is not only more beautiful than the world. He is the only One who loves you with an everlasting love (Jeremiah 31:3).

"Turn to me and be saved, all the ends of the earth!" (Isaiah 45:22). *"Behold, the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!"* (John 1:29).

Notes and sources

Interpretation notes

- **Ezekiel 28 and Isaiah 14** address the kings of Tyre and Babylon. Reading Satan behind them is an old and widely held interpretation, not plain text. The Hebrew of Ezekiel 28:12 ("signet of perfection") is difficult.
- **Lucifer as a worship leader or original high priest** (Andrew Selley) is a traditional reading, not stated in the text; it has been left out here.
- **Venus and Jesus.** Venus reflects the sun; Jesus does not reflect borrowed light. The morning star image is used for Jesus as the herald of the new day.
- **The Cullinan "glass" story** is a popular anecdote, not confirmed in the main sources.

Sources

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